Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, 15-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

```
· helix
· helix <file>
· helix <file1> <file2> … <filen>
· helix -help
· hx in some distributions or by alias
```

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
                v – enter select mode
                3 – select 3
                w – words
                d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
               wd – delete word
               xc – change line
               %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape metachars with backslash when searching for literal value.

```
                . – any character
                * – zero or more
                + – one or more
                ? – zero or one / lazy modifier
                ^ – start of line / negation in class
                $ – end of line
              ( ) – capture group
              [ ] – character class
              { } – repetition count
                | – alternation
                \ – escape character itself
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
            u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
      Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
     :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span
                   (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
        <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
              Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
              :wq – write current buffer and quit
         :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
             :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
              :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
         :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
         :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
        :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
        :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
              ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
              ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
               gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
               ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
               ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
               ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
           <enter> – open selected in current view
            Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
            Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
              :n – create new scratch buffer
             :bc – close current buffer
            :bca – close all buffers
            :bco – close all but current buffer
             :bn – next buffer
              ␣b – open buffer picker
              ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
              gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
              gn – go to next buffer
              gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
         ␣ws / ␣wv – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
        ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
              ␣wq – close current split
              ␣wo – close all but current split
              ␣ww – next split
        ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
        ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
              ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
                Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
           zz, zc – align to center
               zt – align to top
               zb – align to bottom
               zm – align to middle horizontally
               zj – scroll down
               zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
            :tutor – open tutorial
               ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
            h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
           gh, g| – beginning of line
           <nn>g| – column <nn>
               gl – end of line
               gg – top of file
     <nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
               ge – bottom of file
               gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word
               g. – to last modification in current file
               gj – down textual line
               gk – up textual line
               gs – first non-white-space char
               gt – top of screen
               gc – middle of screen
               gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
               gd – go to definition
               gy – go to type definition
               gr – go to references
               gi – go to implementation

               ]d – next diagnostic
               [d – prior diagnostic
               ]D – last diagnostic
               [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
           ]f, [f – to next, prior function
           ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
           ]T, [T – to next, prior test
           ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
           ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
           ]g, [g – to next, prior change
           ]G, [G – to last, first change

           Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
           Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
           Ctrl-b – page up
           Ctrl-f – page down
           Ctrl-u – half page up
           Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
                % – select whole file
           Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
           Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
           Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
           Alt-i – shrink selection
               ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
   ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch>
                     below:
             w / W – word / WORD
                 p – paragraph
      (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
                 m – closest surround pair
                 f – function
                 t – type or class
                 a – argument/parameter
                 c – comment
                 T – test
                 g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
             w / W – to start of next word / WORD
             e / E – to end of current word / WORD
             b / B – to start of current word / WORD
                 x – current line, extend by line
                 X – extend to line
           Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
              ]p – to next paragraph
              [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
           Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
           Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
           Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
           Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
           Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
           Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
      f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
      t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
           Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
                v – toggle select mode
              Esc – return to normal
                ) – cycle primary selection forward
                ( – cycle primary selection backward
           Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
      s<regex> – matches become selections
            S – split on match
       Alt-s – split on newlines
     C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
            & – align on primary cursor
   Alt-<minus> – merge selections
   Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
            ,  – remove all except primary selection
       Alt-,   – remove primary selection
         ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
   Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
            K – keep selections matching the regex
       Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
            i – before selection
            a – after selection
            I – at start of line
            A – at end of line
            o – add line and insert below cursor
            O – add line and insert above cursor
          Esc – end insert (return to normal)
            . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
           ]␣ – newline below
           [␣ – newline above
      ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
            d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
       Alt-d – delete, no save
      md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
            c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
       Alt-c – change, no save
            = – format by LSP
  mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
            > – Indent line(s) containing selection
            < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
            ~ – change case
            ` – set lowercase
       Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
      ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
           ␣C – Toggle block comment
      ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
       Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
       Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
            J – join lines in a selection
       Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
      <under> – trim whitespace from selection
  :reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
        :sort – sort ranges in selection
     :format – format file using external formatter / language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
            y – selection -> yank buf
            p – paste yank buf after the cursor
            P – paste yank buf before the cursor
           ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
           ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
      ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
           ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
       r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
            R – replace selection with yank buf
            " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
      /<regex> – search forward for regex
      ?<regex> – search backward for regex
         n, N – next, previous match
            * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
       Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
      "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
     "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
     "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
     "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
     "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
     "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
           Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
           Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
           Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
               ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
               mm – go to matching delim
          mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
          ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
          ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
          md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
     mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
                | – replace selection(s) with output
           Alt-| – ignore output
                ! – insert output before each selection(s)
           Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
                $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
               ␣G – debug - experimental
               ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
               ␣s – open document symbol picker
               ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
               ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
               ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
               ␣r – rename symbol
               ␣a – apply code action
               ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
            :config-open – open the config file
  :config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
           :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
               ␣' – open last picker
               ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                Ctrl-r – insert a register content
      Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
        Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
  Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
               Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
             Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line

     <Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> – usual meaning but discouraged
  <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
                Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
                   <enter> – open selected
                     <tab> – select next completion item
                <backtab> – select previous completion item
                     Alt-b – backward a word
                     Ctrl-b – backward a char
                     Alt-f – forward a word
                     Ctrl-f – forward a char
                     Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                     Ctrl-a – to prompt start
      Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
        Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                     Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                     Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
                <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
                 <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                     Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be
                              changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                     Ctrl-p – select previous history
                     Ctrl-n – select next history
                     Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by
                              following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
     Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
          <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                        <Home> – to first entry
                         <End> – to last entry
            Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
          Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                      <enter> – open selected
                 Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
                               closing the picker
                     Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                     Ctrl-v – open vertically
                     Ctrl-t – toggle preview
                Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
           Ctrl-u – scroll up
           Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
     Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
           Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
                <enter> – close menu and accept completion
                 Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
           Alt-p – previous signature
           Alt-n – next signature
```